

ANNA NAGAR

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Avadi » Ayyappakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills

Are pedestrians 'dispensable' at Millers Road junction?

Metro Rail work has 'redrawn' the junction of Millers Road and Purasawalkam High Road, and in the new scheme of things, traffic regulation rests with the CMRL marshals. And the revised arrangement does not help pedestrians including a good number of school students

R. RAGU

The Millers Road-Purasawalkam High Road junction is much trodden, being treated to the footwear of those standing on both sides of display cases at the shops on Purasawalkam High Road: shoppers and shopkeepers. On the way to these shops, their ability to keep a stiff upper lip and take unruly motoring behaviour in their stride is challenged at this junction. Obviously, those associated with the shopping experience constitute just one section of the suffering pedestrian population out there; there are also school students and regular commuters finding the going tough at this junction.

Schools nearby include ELM. Fabricius Higher Secondary School on Purasawalkam High Road and Kola Saraswathi Vaishnav Higher Secondary School on Barnaby Road. Further away on Ormes Road are other schools (CSI Bain's School and Shri M. Ct. Muthiah Memorial Matriculation Higher Secondary School), some of



Millers Road junction.
PHOTOS: R. RAGU

CMRL work (Phase II Corridor 3; for the visually oriented, Purple Line), has redrawn the contours of this junction. But that should not be an excuse for lack of traffic regulation. The staff working at the shops on Purasawalkam High Road point out that the junction does not have traffic police personnel. In the absence of traffic signals, their presence would be hugely valuable. Instead, a lone CMRL marshal watches over the junction, but presence instils little fear in motorists, who do not slow down for the pedestrians to cross the junction. Motorists who follow traffic rules conscientiously are also in for a rude shock often as they are up against those motorists who throw those rules to the wind.

These shop workers come from various other parts of the city: Ayanavaram, Otteri, Vysarpadi and Koratur, to name a few localities. They seek a safe passage through the junction.

whose students also navigate this junction.

In the absence of traffic signals at this junction (removed on account of Metro Rail work) and with the alternative regulatory mechanism proving less than impressive, there are multiple rules for motorists, each of them free to script their own. A ready example can be seen rolling down Brick Kiln Road, which is the third component of the intersection.

Vehicular traffic is fed into this junction through Brick Kiln Road, often illegally with motorists taking a forbidden right turn at the junction.



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‘School road in Villivakkam battered’



Mounsamy Madam Street in Villivakkam.

M. SENTHIL

Mounsamy Madam Street in Villivakkam is in a bad shape. Stormwater drain work which began a year ago moves at a slow pace. This is a narrow lane. Two schools are located here and therefore, it witnesses heavy traffic during peak hours causing congestion. The dug up

road has reduced the motorable portion in the lane and this add to the chaos. The Greater Chennai Corporation is requested to complete the work at the earliest and restore the road.

The street falls under Ward 94 in Zone 8 - Anna Nagar.

M. Senthil is a resident of Villivakkam

‘Road in Seneerkuppam waits for relaying’

VALARMATHI . K

VGN Narmada Enclave, a street in VGN Avenue, a residential colony in Seneerkuppam Village Panchayat in Poonamallee, is marked by potholes. The other streets and roads in VGN Avenue were relaid last year. But VGN Narmada Enclave was left out. Sobha Serene Residents’ Association, a gated community in the locality learnt from the Panchayat officials, that VGN Narmada Enclave was included in the list of roads selected for relaying. For reasons unknown, the street has not been relaid.

Therefore, since December 2025, the Association is pursuing this issue with the authorities including the Councillor of Seneerkuppam Village Panchayat, Poonamallee Block Development Office, MLA of Poonamallee Constituency, and the Thiruvallur District Collector. A resolution to relay the road in VGN Narmada Enclave was also passed at the Grama Sabha meeting held on January 26, 2026.

Then the authorities said that the the road would be relaid after the State Assembly elections which was held on April 23. However, the road has not been relaid to this day.

It may be noted that VGN Narmada Enclave is in a deplorable state for nearly a decade-and-a half. Citing its poor condition, drivers of school vehicles do not enter



VGN Narmada Enclave, a street at VGN Avenue in Seneerkuppam on July 30, 2026. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the street. Senior citizens need to exercise extreme caution. During the rainy season, the road goes from bad to worse.

The association requests the

authorities to ensure that the VGN Narmada Enclave is relaid before the onset of north-east monsoon.

Valarmathi . K is a resident of Seneerkuppam

An unsafe dash across the tracks at Thiruvottiyur

IVA FELCHIA P

Well over four years ago, the Railway Level Crossing 4 at Annamalai Nagar, between Thiruvottiyur and Wimco Nagar, was shut “temporarily” to build a Road Under Bridge. I was in Class VII when the barricades came up during the pandemic. Today I am in college, and the gate is still closed. For thousands of residents of Theradi and nearby streets, the promise of a subway has turned into a daily detour, and for many others, a dangerous shortcut across the tracks.

Every morning, school children with backpacks, elders, and office-goers walk along the railway line because the only alternative is a long route to Thiruvottiyur High Road. At night the pathway is dark making it especially unsafe for women. In emergencies, ambulances and two-wheelers lose critical minutes taking the longer road. Residents say there have been several accidents and deaths over the years as people, including students, are forced to cross the tracks. What was meant to im-



Residents want a safe pedestrian passage until the work is completed.

prove connectivity has instead cut off the whole neighborhood.

Before the gate was closed, we could reach the main road in five minutes. Now even to buy medicines or drop a child at school, re-

sidents have to walk an extra two kilometres. Parents say they are most worried in the mornings and evenings when students walk on the tracks to get to schools in Thiruvottiyur. With no lights and bro-

ken stretches on the makeshift walkway, women returning from work avoid the route after sunset.

Southern Railway officials had said the Road Under Bridge at LC-4 was being built to ease traffic and improve safety. But years after work began, there is little clarity on when it will be completed. Civic groups in the area have repeatedly petitioned for temporary measures: proper lighting, a fenced pedestrian path and regular police

presence.

We residents are not asking for a clear deadline for the RUB, interim lighting and barricading along the walkway, and a safe pedestrian passage until the work is completed. Southern Railway and Greater Chennai Corporation must coordinate and treat this as an urgent public safety issue, not a project stuck in files.

Iva Felchia P is a resident of Theradi, Thiruvottiyur

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Bazaar Road in Mylapore.

Metro works, loyalty works too

With Metro Rail work taking over a vast chunk of Kutchery Road, footfall at Bazaar Road in Mylapore has reduced. Despite the odds, old enterprises on this retail street have reasons to stay positive

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

At the point where Kutchery Road is “amputated” by Metro Rail work, two streets peel away in opposite directions. The workaday realities of these two streets, Devadi Street and Bazaar Road, are also on contrasting trajectories ever since this work took over a section of Kutchery Road shutting it down for regular traffic. Devadi Street has become overly industrious working indefatigably shoulder-to-shoulder with Nadu Street to funnel vehicular traffic from North Mada Street into Kutchery Road towards Santhome High Road. It also entertains wheels from Appu Street. While wheels have increased on Devadi Street, the footfall has simultaneously reduced on Bazaar Road.

Shopping is a languid, leisurely experience; hive off the comfort factor and you detract a vital component from that experience. When Kutchery Road was fully available to motorists and pedestrians, shopping on Bazaar Road felt natural. Now, with diversions and circuitous detours, it feels forced. Unless there are strong reasons to transact business over a shop counter, people are going to find alternatives; and digital pathways keep those alternatives flowing freely.

But Bazaar Road is attractive on account of enterprises that have established a strong presence over decades of retail commerce. Amidst shops that have regularly changed their name boards and trade are a multiplicity of enterprises that have persisted with one trade and built immense social cap-

ital, installing an emotional hotline with its customers. Examples abound. Here is a handful of them.

As anywhere else, a strong USP principle works like a charm. For A. Bhaskar, who runs Jayakumar Mill (which is around 70 years old) as well as a chekku oil shop, along with his brother A. Kumar, his grinding machines stay heard on Bazaar Road above the subterranean rumble of tunnel-boring machines on Kutchery Road because of unique offerings.

The machines grind the familiar. To name a few, rice, gram, and wheat flour, turmeric, vermilion and ragi and health mixes for young mothers after childbirth. And one machine grinds *nalangu maavu* (herbal bath power), and that has made a huge difference. Besides, as Bhaskar points out, his customers value the fact that this mill dedicates a grinding machine to each variety of items to be ground. So, business keeps plopping into those wide funnel-shaped feed hoppers. The challenge, Bhaskar observes, is more from people's increasing preference for packaged foods than the reduced access caused by Metro Rail work. Bhaskar believes opening even one access route on the Metro Rail-impacted section of Kutchery Road could bring back some of the footfall.

A similar disruption has affected New Shiva Country Drugs and Herbs on Bazaar Road, says its owner R. Prakash. Nearly 90 years old, the store began as a herbal medicine shop under Prakash's grandfather and gradually expanded into pooja articles, dry fruits, and bamboo products. With monsoon come sniffles, and a rush of customers,

but through the year, there is a steady flow of commerce, thanks to older customers who grew up relying on country remedies and younger ones who have inherited that faith from their families. Prakash notes that New Shiva has branches at Thanithurai Market and North Mada Street, also in Mylapore.

Scattered presence helps, particularly in these times. Prakash notes that online business of country medicine is greater challenge to ford.

For seller of earthen pots Gunasundari N., the going is palpably tough. But the resilience is tougher still. The thinning of the customer base, she believes, has resulted largely from changing lifestyles, the earthen pots she sells cracking under the magnetic pull of ever-silver wares. The pots, once a familiar presence in Mylapore homes, are in an unequal battle with ever-silver and aluminium vessels that promise convenience and durability. Obviously, the challenge glowering at Gunasundari is not only a metallic shift in tastes. The road itself poses a challenge now, as it now draws fewer people stopping to browse or buy.

Her voice drops to a plaintive murmur when she says, “There are days I go home without earning anything.” But brining the curtains down on the business does not enter her mind. That resilience pretty much sums up the attitude of the old shops at Bazaar Road in Mylapore.

Ahead of Madras Day, Resilience Series tracks old markets in the city that are under the shadow of a major civic infrastructure work but are soldiering on with inimitable poise

The icing on the cake

Though 121 years old, The Crown Bakery on Bazaar Road stays young, thanks to suggestions coming in from Gen Zers in the family that runs the enterprise

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

At Bazaar Road in Mylapore, lined with a diversity of shops, “hoary-haired” enterprises show up with impressive frequency. Established in 1905, The Crown Bakery wins the demographic tug-of-war among these old enterprises hands down.

Established in 1905 by Kanthasamy Mudaliar, the reins of the shop would be passed on to the current family, the descendants of Srinivasan, an admirable torch-bearer of this patiently baked legacy, for several decades.

While Srinivasan's daughter Bhavani Srinivasan manages the shop, the younger generation is parked in the wings, stepping in from time to time to bring its own energy and ideas to the oven.

Twenty-three-year-old Keerthana V, Bhavani's niece and Srinivasan's granddaughter and one who epitomises the Gen Z engagement, recalls a brainstorming session by the Gen Zers in the family that resulted in the introduction of ice cream cakes to the bakery's bill of fare.

The younger generation's suggestions were instrumental in the introduction of puffs and pastries and those ice cream cakes, bringing contemporariness to the bakery's repertoire.

On the subject of repertoire, the bakery also continues to make soup sticks, a simple and traditional product given to babies during teething. But there is no

cause for the old offerings (breads and buns, bun-butter jam and regular cakes) to feel threatened by this New-Age approach. The bun-butter jam remains a clear favourite with each serving prepared freshly in front of the customer rather than packaged and left on the shelf.

The old recipes remain unchanged, preserved on yellowed pieces of paper, written in an ink that defies erasure. “We do not try to fit in a particular box or overly modernise anything,” says Keerthana.

This balance is likely the reason it manages to keep its customer base as well as add steadily to it. She observes, “People have always liked what we produced over the years and hence they keep coming back.” The connection the bakery has maintained with its customers is most evident during the Yule tide. Ahead of Christmas, Crown bakery's rum-soaked plum cake, prepared with dried fruits and raisins soaked in rum for months, draws customers from across the city and beyond. Some even send cakes abroad to relatives. “I myself was craving cakes while I was in the United Kingdom and my family has sent it over multiple times,” Keerthana says.

If The Crown Bakery has managed to ford challenges in recent times, including reduced access to its doors due to Metro Rail work, it is the desire to see the enterprise survive time that is shared by family members across generations. Specifically, the Gen Z factor: there are eight grandchildren in the family. And this constituency takes pride in the bakery. Keerthana notes she or any other youngster in the family will be honoured to take it forward.



The Crown Bakery at Bazaar Road in Mylapore.



During a Solar Mela organised by CAG at Kasturba Nagar. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Rooftop solar gets a fresh boost

The Tamil Nadu government announces an additional incentive to accelerate investment in solar technology. What should it focus on next?

LIFFY THOMAS

With Tamil Nadu government announcing an additional incentive of ₹22,000 for domestic consumers to instal a solar rooftop, the sun is expected to shine brighter in the state.

Under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yagna, a maximum subsidy of ₹78,000 for solar rooftop capacity of above 3kW is already being given. Combining the two incentives, a beneficiary can receive a total benefit of ₹1 lakh.

While those working to promote the renewable energy sector are happy with the announcement made during the Tamil Nadu Budget session held recently and are waiting for the modalities in the scheme to be made clearer, they weigh in with their suggestions.

P. Ashok Kumar, founder-president of Tamil Nadu Solar Energy Developers Association (TNSEDA), has sent a letter to the State Government to modify the scheme in such a way that energy storage devices solar batteries and inverters get a push.

“Instead of giving a direct benefit of ₹22,000, the State Government should insist consumers use energy storage devices. My suggestion is to add energy storage to the incentive and train people to use solar power 24x7 even in peak hours to reduce the dependence on Tamil Nadu Electricity Board,” says Ashok.

The current practice in Tamil Nadu is a consumer’s excess solar power is sent to the grid, letting him/her use that credit later instead of paying cash called Net Metering.

TNSEDA representation holds significance as renewable energy alone is

not enough to meet growing energy needs. Batteries are said to bolster grid stability and performance, allowing renewables to better integrate into the electrical grid. Energy storage devices will allow the energy generated during peak times to be used at a later time.

Ashok Kumar says such a nudge by the government will reduce the loss incurred by TNEB. “The cost of purchasing peak hour power is high, so the extra incentive should nudge consumers to use solar during peak hours,” he says.

Many states including those leading in solar rooftop adoption like Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat offer subsidy.

More awareness

Jaideep Saraswat, Associate Director - Clean Power, Electric Mobility and Emerging Technologies, Vasudha Foundation, a non-profit think tank working to advance clean energy and climate solutions, says their experience with accelerating PM Surya Ghar Yagna shows that a subsidy translates into real adoption only when all the pieces fit well.

“This begins with raising consumer awareness on rooftop solar systems and informing consumers about the state subsidy, which improves the pay-back period for them. Concurrently, vendor capacity must be built to ensure optimised system deployment,” says Jaideep. “Finally, the capacity of all stakeholders needs to be built and everyone must be aligned on increasing rooftop deployment.”

Other suggestions include: speed up approval process and set targets for banks and financial institutions so that more household are able to avail loan for installing solar systems.

An experience hub

Before investing in solar power, visit one of these experience centres

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

When it comes to solar energy, experiencing is believing. At least that is idea retailers and manufacturers have started to promote, thereby nudging homeowners to transition to green energy. From first-hand exposure to solar solutions at experience centres to deploying staff at electronic stores to clarifying nagging doubts, the reasons to invest in solar energy seem to be slowly increasing for consumers.

In June, VeSat Solar Energy Systems opened a new solar experience centre at Shastri Nagar in Adyar. The building is powered entirely by solar energy including its lights, fans and three air conditioners, computers and television.

Those walking into the showroom get to see how the power of the sun can be harnessed on a range of products from water heaters to power systems.

L.R. Venkatesh, managing director, VeSat Solar, says giving prospective buyers a walk-through is not just an easy way to market a product but boosts the trust and confidence in solar energy.

“Solar is not an off the shelf product. Once you give people the experience, we visit the site, study their requirement and design it accordingly,” says Venkatesh.

Chennai-based Evolve Energy Group and Freyr Energy are among others that are fast expanding their experience centres.

Solar section in consumer outlets

Increasingly consumer durable outlets have expanded the scope of items they retail by including solar.

The 10 plus outlets of Darling Retail in Chennai, a multi-brand consumer durable chain, has staff trained to give shoppers a demo on how solar technology works. Under Darling Solar Solutions, the enterprise offers a range of services. Once a customers evinces interest, the technical team does a site inspection to study the roof size, structure, shading and energy needs. From loan application process to applying for net meter, they even support a buyer with annual maintenance.

Likewise, Ratna Fan House also offers a variety of services and has completed more than 200 solar rooftop installations so far.

Solar Mela in Alwarpet today

Citizen Consumer and Civic Action Group (CAG) is organising a Solar Mela on August 16 at C.P. Art Centre, Eldams Road, Alwarpet, from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m, bringing together solar vendors, banks and EB officials on a common platform for consumers. Those keen on switching to solar power can have answers to questions such as how much they can save on their electricity bill with rooftop solar, installation and government subsidy related queries, choosing a right vendor and financing options that are available. To invite CAG for a similar mela in your locality, call Subramani at 88072 14008/ Aswin at 9047933740



SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Water moves in two directions across the Nemmeli coastal wetland — freshwater flowing east from inland lakes and tanks, and seawater moving inland through the Muttukadu estuary. Spread across more than 8,500 acres between Kelambakkam and Mamallapuram, the wetland is a meeting point of these two water systems, shaped by tides, rainfall and the seasons.

That landscape is now being reshaped into a freshwater reservoir. The first phase of Mamallan reservoir project covers 4,375 acres. A second phase is proposed for the remaining wetland.

The proposed reservoir will occupy a landscape marked by marshes, mudflats, shallow waters, salt pans and seasonal grasslands, spanning freshwater and brackish-water habitats. The wetland is also a seasonal stopover along the Central Asian Flyway, drawing migratory birds, while its waters support fish, prawns, crabs and other species that sustain fishing activity in the surrounding villages.

The wetland is also being documented from the ground up. Environmental groups and naturalists are recording its biodiversity through field surveys, documentaries, signature campaigns, rallies and a coffee-table book.

Nemmel's Last Tide, a documentary conceptualised by Deepak Venkatachalam of Suzhal Arivom, a grassroot level, volunteer-driven environmental education, research, and conservation group and produced by the Wetland Conservation Network, brings together voices from naturalists, scientists, maritime researchers, educators and fisher-folks to document what the wetland holds and what could be

Documentation as advocacy

Environmental groups are turning to documentary film-making and biodiversity documentation and other strategies to create awareness on how the Mamallan reservoir project would reshape the Kovalam–Nemmeli wetlands for the worse

lost.

According to Deepak, making people see the landscape is central to conservation. "We try to break that barrier by bringing in people and increasing the footfall to these places," he says, describing the need to reconnect people with nature through direct experience and visual storytelling. "The landscape has so much life. It is a very complex, intricate ecosystem. It cannot be recreated at any cost once it is depleted."

That life is reflected in the numbers. Suzhal Arivom's documentation records 232 species in the Nemmeli Wetland complex, with nearly 45,000 birds counted during the 2025-26 peak season. A count of 16,000 migratory ducks, spread across half-a-dozen species, was recorded.

The wetland is also an important node in the Central Asian Flyway, with 88 migratory species recorded.

The documentation extends beyond birds. In January 2026, Suzhal Arivom recorded a established colony of Burmann's Sundew (*Drosera burmannii*) at five GPS-verified locations. The tiny carnivorous plant survives in acidic, nutrient-poor, seasonally waterlogged soils making its presence an indicator of relatively

undisturbed wetland conditions.

A parallel effort has come from the Palluyir Trust, a group for Nature Education and Research, founded in 2021 by naturalists, through its coffee-table book *Kovalam-Nemmeli Coastal Wetland: A Biodiversity Montage*. Combining photographs with species information, the book records the wetland's birds, insects, benthic life, mangroves and other flora. Crucially, it was printed and sent to bureaucrats, MLAs and government authorities, accompanied by letters highlighting the wetland's ecological importance and concerns over the proposed reservoir. A digital version is also available on their official website.

The documentation also places these species within the wider wetland ecosystem, its mudflats, marshes, shallow waters and vegetation which provide feeding and breeding grounds for aquatic life and habitat for migratory birds. It also records the wetland's links to fishing livelihoods and

flood protection.

"The idea is we are trying as many strategies as possible to make people feel for that place and be moved by the life there," Yuvan says. For him, the question is also whether a freshwater reservoir can ever be considered an "alternative" to this landscape. "A freshwater body does not belong by the beach," he argues, pointing to the difference between inland reservoirs and tidal wetlands.

Fewer fish, less income

Fisherfolk from more than 16 villages depend on the Kovalam-Nemmeli wetlands, with nearly 7,000 families relying on its shallow waters to collect prawns, crabs, oysters and other species. Unlike mechanised fishers, they work largely by hand and foot, following Irall Thazhuvuthal, the traditional practice of catching prawns and fish by hand. The Paraval, as they locally call the coastal wetland, has 18 distinct habitats, with the Purattasi season (mid-September to mid-October) bringing the highest catch. During this period, a family can earn ₹1 lakh-₹3 lakh, an income that can sustain them through much of the year.

The proposed reservoir threa-

tens this livelihood system. About 5,000 acres of the wetland is proposed to be converted into an impounded freshwater reservoir, with Phase I covering 65% Kazhuveli marshland and 35% Uppan-gazhi salt pans. For fisherfolk who have depended on these waters for generations, the loss could mean shrinking incomes and a shift to unfamiliar and precarious work.

For Kovalam R. Narayanan, the impact of the Mamallan Reservoir Project can be measured in the distance between what fishing once earned his family and what it brings in today. A fisherman from Kovalam, Narayanan began fishing at 11 and has continued in the occupation for decades. The earnings have now dwindled considerably. Narayanan links the decline partly to what has happened to fishermen who once worked in the coastal wetlands. As access to the wetland has reduced with the progress of the reservoir project, he said, many of those fishermen have moved to the sea.

That has changed the arithmetic of fishing. "Earlier, there were around 500 fishermen fishing in the sea and another 500 depending on the wetlands. Now all 1,000 are going to the sea," he said. More boats and more fishers are consequently chasing the same marine catch, he said, leaving each fisher with a smaller share. "The wetlands earmarked for the project are not an empty expanse waiting to be developed. They are a living ecosystem supporting an intricate network of species and livelihoods" said Narayanan.

Link to the documentary <https://tinyurl.com/NemmeliDoc>
Palluyir Trust - @palluyir-trust.org

Rich bird life at Kovalam–Nemmeli wetlands



Good show by Sankalp - The Open School



Sankalp - The Open School, She-noy Nagar, which has supported children with learning and developmental challenges for 26 years, enabling them to complete their 10th and 12th NIOS Board examinations, has bagged a 100% pass percentage, says a press release.

Sankalp is now an accredited NIOS Study Centre under SAIED, offering academic courses for learners with disabilities, the release

adds.

Its holistic approach combines multisensory teaching, simplified learning materials and individualised support with speech and language therapy, occupational therapy and arts-based therapy, the press release says. These integrated interventions strengthen communication, functional skills, learning abilities, creativity and self-confidence, it adds.

Workshop on making cookies

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a workshop on making cookies on August 20. According to a press release, the session will focus on making cookies from millets, indigenous rice varieties. Another workshop on making bee-

keeping will be held on August 21. The sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Opposite CIPET, Guindy. Prior registration is necessary, adds the press release. For details, call 044 - 29530048

TN Governor soft-launches MSS App

Recently, TN Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, soft-launched the MSS App (MSME Schemes Search App) at Bharathiar Mandapam in Lok Bhavan, Chennai.

The application has been jointly developed by Swadeshi Shodh Sansthan (SSS) - Tamil Nadu Chapter and Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology with the objective of enabling MSMEs and aspiring youth to easily discover and access Government schemes, financial assistance programmes through a single digital platform, says a press release. The application is designed to simplify access to information relating to Central and State Government initiatives, particularly for first-generation entrepreneurs and citizens in ru-



ral and semi-urban areas. The initial release supports both English and Tamil, with additional fea-

tures and services proposed in subsequent phases, the release adds.

SACAS students join statewide anti-drug pledge



On August 11, the Home, Prohibition and Excise Department, Government of Tamil Nadu, organised the Mass Anti-Drug Pledge 2026 on 11 August 2026 at Presidency College.

Representing S.A. College of Arts & Science, 50 students and two faculty members participated in the event. The participants joined the statewide initiative by taking the Anti-Drug Pledge and expressing their commitment to preventing drug abuse and promoting healthy lifestyles, says a press release.

Cycle rally held



The naval cadets of KRM Public School took out a cycle rally as part of the Independence Day celebration. Displaying the National Flag on the handlebars, the cadets cycled with pride and patriotic fervour, says a press release.

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Onam festivities from August 17

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan celebrates Onam with a five-day festival titled “Bhavanonam” starting August 17 at its main auditorium in Mylapore. The events happening from August 17 to 21 are open to all and begin at 6.30 p.m.

From captivating Kathakali, Malayalam short plays, Kerala musical ensemble like Thiruvathirakali, Mudiattam, Panchari Melam, Ottanthulal, the festival will immerse audiences in the unique charm of God's Own Country.

The events on August 23 will be held at the Kilpauk auditorium.

August 17 - Kathakali - Naragasura Vadham

August 18 - Kerala musical ensemble

August 20 - Malayalam short plays

August 21 - Avani - A Kerala cultural odyssey

Celebrate Madras Day with MTC

As part of Madras Day, the Metropolitan Transport Corporation is organising ‘MTC Chennai Day 2026’ with a host of competitions.

Drawing competition

For students of classes I to V, the themes are ‘The Bus Transporting Me to School’, ‘My Family Members Commute by MTC Buses’, and ‘My Colourful Chennai Bus’; classes VI to VIII: ‘My Chennai, My Bus’, ‘An Unforgettable Journey in an MTC Bus’, and ‘MTC Buses and Green Chennai’; and classes IX to XII, ‘My view

of MTC Bus in 2040’, and ‘One-Day in the life of MTC Bus’.

Short film contest

Madras Reel, a short-film competition, is on ‘One Bus Story’ where participants should drive home the message that buses play a vital role in serving commuters in their day-to-day lives. The daily life of buses, their memories, their feelings, and the city's unique culture experienced while travelling on a bus must be captured.

The short film should feature MTC buses and run for three minutes.

The photography com-

petition is on ‘Route Number tells a life story’. The photos should depict MTC buses and commuters, public transport featuring city pictures and moments. The participants should explain how the buses are interlinked with Chennai's lives.

Poetry competition is on ‘Namma Chennai Bus’.

The submission link for contests: drawing: <https://forms.gle/Jnbpw4MWPaD6TMkA8>, photography: <https://forms.gle/8Scf4Vw>

VQIXWdmT69, short film : mtcchennaisocialmedia@gmail.com
The last date to send the entries is August 18, 2026. For details, visit <https://x.com/MtcChennai>

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Last date to register: August 18, 2026